

- Yoghurt baked chicken with tomato, onion and mint salad
- Pea and lemon risotto
- Beef in a Thai salad.

When you shop, add up the cost of every item you toss into the trolley as you go. Always shop with a calculator, to ensure you track under your budget.

***Takeaway coffee
(about \$10, i.e. no more than two a week)***

Coffee has become a totem for the struggle of the first home buyer. I'd love a dollar for every expert who recommended curbing takeaway coffee intake to achieve a deposit. I hate to say it, but I subscribe in part to the theory. It's the slight, almost unnoticeable spending that accumulates over time. First home buyers fight for the right to latte, but at more than \$4 a pop, a daily cup is a significant slab of pocket money. I have learned to measure simple pleasures in my life against other needs that money could go towards – a takeaway brew is half a day of public transport travel, or half a glass of wine in the company of good friends on the weekend.

If you cannot give up coffee, substitute the potential savings in this bracket somewhere else; for example, by curbing petrol in favour of using public transport.

I have a takeaway coffee twice a week – one during the working week, usually on the most strenuous day, and at brunch on Saturday. Yes, I have brunch at a nice café, because I am so disciplined in other ways and it's not an impost on my savings.

To combat the cost of coffee, I bought a second-hand espresso machine – for a song on Gumtree, and it works perfectly – and have a morning coffee at home. Setting the alarm an extra 20 minutes early to sit by the window and have a quiet cup is a ritual that costs me just under a dollar a day. (I've included the cost of milk in that equation, and factor the coffee pods into groceries every few weeks.)

Toiletries and medicines (about \$15 a week)

Have you heard of Mecca Cosmetica? I used to be in their highest spending bracket – a dubious honour bestowed on those who spend at least \$1200 a